MORARJI DESAI

1896–1995



“THE VERY SPIRIT OF INDIA ABHORS DICTATORSHIP.”

Morarji Desai was a conservative Congress politician who was active in the nationalist movement and member of state- and national-level governments. In 1966, Desai hoped to become prime minister after LB Shastri’s sudden death, but he lost out to Indira Gandhi. After briefly serving on her cabinet, he was, from 1969, one of her staunchest critics. His protests against her government led to him being imprisoned during the Emergency. He fought the 1977 elections as a member of the Janata Party and became India’s first non-Congress prime minister. However, his tenure was marred by infighting among the parties of the coalition government and he resigned in 1979.